

Roman owned multiple homes. He had sweatpants that cost hundreds of dollars. He was older than me and more successful, and he abused the power imbalance in our relationship to make me very insecure. Dating him as a non-rich person, I felt pressure to present myself as if I were above my station. I wore high heels more often. I got my hair done whenever I thought we would see each other. I scrutinized my wardrobe, suddenly unsure about the strings coming off my cheap Forever 21 outfits. (Seriously, why do they always have strings?)

I learned that while dating someone with no money made me spend more, dating someone with a lot of money ALSO made me spend more. One of the reasons my relationship with Roman ended is that he started secretly dating another woman, a fellow famous person who was wealthy like him. (I found out we were broken up when he showed up on a red carpet with her. Like I said, NEVER EVER DATE A FAMOUS MAN.) I don't know how much being in the same economic bracket affected their relationship, but I imagine it probably made it easier for them to understand each other. Maybe it's simpler to date within your financial sphere.

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After two relationships with two men of very different financial means, I started dating a feminine woman who was still looking for a post-college job. I didn't have a disposable income, but I felt an obligation to take care of her the way I cared for my improviser ex. (Fatal flaw: I love a project.)

Even though neither of us was a cisgender man and we could have avoided classic gender roles, I subconsciously decided (without asking her) that I should take on the more traditional masculine "provider" role. I believed in her and thought, "Eventually we'll be on the same playing field, and it'll all be fine." I was further along in my career and making more money, but I wasn't anywhere near financially stable. It started to stress me out to be responsible for someone else when I was just becoming responsible for myself, even though she never asked me to do that. Money came between us without us ever actually talking about it.